

The Tantra Called the Compendium of Vajra Wisdom

Vajrajñānasamuccaya-nāma-tantra · Toh 447 · Derge Kangyur

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The Compendium of Vajra Wisdom, known in Sanskrit as the Vajrajñānasamuccaya-nāma-tantra and in Tibetan as Yeshe Dorje Künle Tupa (yeshe rdo rje kun las btus pa), is a Buddhist tantra concerned with the nature of wisdom, mind, and ignorance as understood through the framework of the three vajras — the vajra body, speech, and mind of all the Tathāgatas. The text takes the form of a dialogue in which the bodhisattva Maitreya and a great assembly of bodhisattvas question the Blessed One, who responds by revealing the intrinsic nature of wisdom arising from these three vajras. It belongs to the class of tantric literature within the Kangyur and is catalogued as Toh 447.

In the language of India: Vajrajñānasamuccaya-nāma-tantra. In the Tibetan language: The Tantra Called the Compendium of Vajra Wisdom.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Just as it was spoken: this is what the Blessed One (the Buddha) declared exactly as it appears in the Tantra of the Compendium of Vajra Wisdom.

Maitreya (Loving-kindness, the bodhisattva) and six thousand other bodhisattvas petitioned the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what are ignorance, that which arises from mind, and that which is called mind?"

The Blessed One, through the vajra of body, speech, and mind of all the Tathāgatas, declared: "Sons of the lineage, listen. Because they arise perfectly from the three vajras of wisdom, they have the intrinsic nature of the three vajras of wisdom."

Maitreya asked: "Blessed One, what is the essential nature of the three vajras of wisdom?"

The Blessed One declared: "The profound ultimate limit — without cessation, without arising. By reason of that condition there is ignorance, which is called ignorance; and there is the appearance of near-attainment; and there is great emptiness. This is difficult to realize. Nevertheless, it must be expressed as accompanied by appearance. Conditioned by ignorance arises that which comes from mind — this is declared to be the radiance of the spread of

appearance and utter emptiness. Conditioned by what arises from mind comes mind itself — this is appearance-and-emptiness. The intrinsic nature of mind, of what arises from mind, and of ignorance is selflessness. All three of these arise from luminosity, and therefore have the intrinsic nature of vajra."

Thereupon all those bodhisattvas — Maitreya and the others — were struck with amazement and fell completely silent. Then the Blessed One, through the vajra of body, speech, and mind of all the Tathāgatas, saw those great bodhisattvas sitting there in silence and declared: "Sons of the lineage, why do you sit without saying anything?"

Thereupon those great bodhisattvas prostrated themselves, touching their heads to both feet of the Blessed One, and petitioned him further: "How wondrous! O Teacher, the supremely profound and difficult-to-realize distinction among the three consciousnesses — please, Blessed One, explain it. Sugata (the Well-Gone One, an epithet of the Buddha), please explain it."

The Blessed One declared: "That very consciousness which arises from luminosity is called mind, mentation, and consciousness. It is the root of all phenomena, and from it — as the nature of defilement and the nature of purification — conceptuality arises as twofold: as self and as other. The vehicle of that consciousness is wind. From wind comes fire. From fire comes water. From water comes earth. From these arise the five aggregates, the six sense sources, and the five sense objects — all of which are consciousness mixed with wind.

"Then, through the luminous display of the intrinsic nature of the three consciousnesses shining out with great clarity, one comes to experience it directly; and through the cause of appearance, the intrinsic natures arise perfectly. In regard to this: luminosity is without location, without cessation, without arising — ultimate truth, the ultimate limit. The dark appearance that arises from it is ignorance. Its intrinsic nature is dullness, error, distraction, forgetfulness, laziness, silence, and obscurity. Ignorance arises from mind — it is like the light of the sun, or like a brilliantly clear mirage. Its intrinsic nature encompasses attachment, joy, supreme joy, intensity, and the like; forms arising as conventionally manifest, assemblies of gods, signs, and the symbolic vajra language. From what arises from mind comes mind itself — it is like moonlight, or like a brilliantly clear reflection of the moon in water."

Its intrinsic nature is freedom from attachment and the like. On the conventional level it is the symbolic sign of women as they directly appear, of

the bhaga, of the lotus, and of assemblies of goddesses. From the wisdom-gnosis that arises through the perfect union of vajra and lotus, fire comes from the exertion of one's own vajra. From fire comes water — appearing first as a softly flowing form, and from that the shimmering, the rippling, and the undulating. Then, from the appearance of freedom from attachment, there arise coagulated clumps of blood. These are produced by semen and blood together. From the joining of the two faculties in equal union comes desire. From desire one must discern freedom from desire and the middle desire. For this reason there is the body — from which arise the crossed-legged postures and so forth that arise from the body, serving as the skillful means of the mudrā of speech; the mantra arising perfectly from the vowels and consonants, serving as the skillful means of the mudrā of speech; and, serving as the skillful means of the mudrā of mind, the deity visualized from rites and signs. The object of form and the rest serves as the skillful means of entering into equal union of the two faculties. The perfect union of vajra and lotus serves as the skillful means of mind and the mental factors. The equal union of mind and mental factors serves as the skillful means of the meditative absorption of great bliss.

This is illustrated by the simile of illusion. Therefore the Tathāgatas, as numerous as the grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā, in all the buddha-fields, are like an illusion, like a reflection of the moon in water, like a floater in the eye, like a mirage, like a dream, like an echo, like a city of gandharvas (scent-eaters), like a magical display, like a rainbow, like lightning, like a water bubble, and like a reflection in a mirror — these twelve similes of illusion illustrate the meditative absorption of great bliss.

Just as butter comes from churning milk, and just as sesame oil comes from sesame, so the vajra illustrates the gnosis of skillful means, and the lotus illustrates the gnosis of wisdom. And just as sesame oil does not arise from milk and sesame without their being properly combined, so too, without the vajra of mantra and mudrā properly brought together and united with the lotus, one cannot illustrate the three consciousnesses. Whoever is unable to unite the bhaga and the liṅga perfectly will not find the meditative absorption of great bliss. One who merely aspires with keen interest to the meditative absorption of great bliss alone will come to dwell on the level of a beginner, and will become a practitioner of non-returner. One who, through the bliss of the perfect union of vajra and lotus, truly and properly illustrates the intrinsic-nature luminosity will come to be firmly established in the state of

great bliss.

This is the hidden explanation.

The great bodhisattvas (bodhisattvas mahāsattvas) asked: Blessed One, what is the general meaning?

The Blessed One declared: The teaching that śrāvakas and others, who practice the Dharma of freedom from attachment and are not yet liberated from the habitual tendencies of conceptual thought, would revile upon hearing the astonishing vajra-language — expressions such as those found in the great yoga tantras that speak of dwelling in the bhaga of a queen, which openly set forth the Dharma of desire — the explanation given here that does not contradict even those people, that is declared to be the explanation of the general meaning.

The great bodhisattvas asked: Blessed One, how was the ultimate presentation of the mode of Dharma engaged in through desire explained?

Then the Blessed One declared: Excellent! Excellent! Bodhisattvas! You who are great bodhisattvas endowed with supreme compassion, listen. The extremes are:

"The mode of luminosity itself is called the ultimate."

The great bodhisattvas asked: Blessed One, by what means is the ultimate attained?

The Blessed One declared: The three extremes of emptiness with respect to the aggregates (skandhas), elements (dhātus), sense bases (āyatanas), and so forth. The extreme of the three emptinesses is luminosity.

The great bodhisattvas asked: Blessed One, how do the three emptinesses come to their ultimate end in luminosity?

The Blessed One declared: Just as fire burns wood and reduces it to ash, so luminosity, through the gnosis of wisdom practiced over a long time, brings about thorough purification. Just as the leaves of a palmyra tree are reduced to ash, so the gnosis of skillful means brings about thorough purification. Just as the petals of cotton wool are burned, so the gnosis of attaining luminosity brings about thorough purification with the utmost swiftness. Therefore, by this sequential process, just as wood, palmyra leaves, and cotton-wool petals are reduced to ash, so emptiness, utter emptiness, and great emptiness are ultimately resolved into luminosity. This is what is declared as the ultimate

explanation.

Maitreya asked: Blessed One, how is it that in the yoga tantras all the Tathāgatas gave their explanation through six extremes?

The Blessed One declared: Through intentional expression (Skt. abhisam̐dhi), through non-intentional expression, through interpretable meaning (Skt. neyārtha), through definitive meaning (Skt. nītārtha), through literal expression, and through non-literal expression.

Maitreya asked: Blessed One, out of your loving compassion, please explain each of these terms one by one.

The Blessed One declared: That which was explained as ultimate is itself intentional expression — for example, vajra-language such as the expressions "neither desire, nor free from desire, nor perceiving anything in between," and so forth — these are intentional expressions. Vajra-language such as "without body, without speech, without mind; selfless; all is empty; pure; luminous," and so forth — these are non-intentional expressions. Vajra-language such as "camphor, great blood, red sandalwood, vajra, lotus, and mudrā," and the like — these are interpretable in meaning. That is: "camphor" means semen; "great blood" means the blood of the monthly sign; "mixed with red sandalwood paste" is red sandalwood; "vajra" is the characteristic mark, that is, the method; "lotus" is the bhaga, that is, wisdom; and "mudrā" and "queen," and so forth — these vajra-language expressions are of definitive meaning. In both tantras, the conduct tantras, and the action tantras, meanings that are stated openly — such as maṇḍala (Skt. maṇḍala), fire offering, tormā offering, medicine, and the collection of activities such as peaceful rites, and likewise the eight great worldly siddhis that are taught — these are literal, that is, they are explained according to the plain verbal meaning.

Kotrākhya, Kotrāba, Kotrāḥ, Kotrābhasta, Kotrirākā, Kolakhya, Kolaba, Kola, Kolabhasta, Kolasthatha — these express the sense faculties and their objects. Vajra-language of this kind and so forth is non-literal expression.

The great bodhisattvas asked: Blessed One, what are the extents of the great yoga tantra, the both tantra, the conduct tantra, the action tantra, and the thought tantra?

The Blessed One declared: The great yoga tantra is named as twelve thousand in title — and when elaborated fully, it is innumerable. The both tantra is six

thousand. The conduct tantra is eight thousand. The action tantra is four thousand. The thought tantra is four thousand.

All of these together make thirty-four thousand. The final letters of the names of tantras and ritual texts are as many as these: ka, kha, ga, gha, ña; ca, cha, ja, jha, ña; ṭa, ṭha, ḍa, ḍha, ṇa; ta, tha, da, dha, na; pa, pha, ba, bha, ma; ya, ra, la, va; śa, ṣa, sa, ha, kṣa. These are the final letters of the letters of names.

The great bodhisattvas asked: Blessed One, what are the activities, the rituals, the objects of accomplishment, and the practice belonging to each of those?

The Blessed One declared: Rising in sequence through the blessing of my own consecration from the ultimate truth, and in order to supremely demonstrate the state of awakening that arises from desire — dwelling fully in the bhaga of a queen by means of the meditative absorption of great bliss of the body of a wheel-turning king, in the midst of the assembly of queens — that which accomplishes and practices through thorough analysis by means of the six limits of vajra-language, which is wondrous and contrary to the conduct of the world, abides in the great yoga tantra. That which accomplishes and practices through thorough analysis of the ten aspects of suchness — namely, the placing upon the maṇḍala wheel together with the vidyā goddesses, and the activities, actions, and practices that arise therefrom — abides in the both tantra. That which is to be accomplished and that which accomplishes — through thorough analysis of the defining characteristics of the visualized great mudrā of the conduct tantra, among the diverse activities involving mudrā — abides in the conduct tantra. That which accomplishes and practices through thorough analysis by means of concepts rooted in fault — specifically: visualizing with a sense of fear and performing extreme purification; the absence of the supreme bliss of a wisdom-being; the absence of divine pride in oneself; the realm not being wondrous; and the domain not being extraordinary — abides in the action tantra. That which accomplishes and practices through thorough analysis of the eight great siddhis — mantra, medicine, fire offering, powder, eye medicine, swift-footedness, and the like — abides in the thought tantra.

The great bodhisattvas asked: Blessed One, what are the seven ornaments?

The Blessed One declared: They are these: the five kinds of introduction, explanation by means of the six limits, four kinds of reasoning, four kinds of explanation, two kinds of division, examination of disciples of five types of person, and the intentions of the two truths.

The five kinds of introduction are these: the name, the purpose for which it was composed, the author, the extent, and the aim.

Explanation by means of the six limits is this: explanation with an intended meaning, explanation without an intended meaning, provisional meaning, definitive meaning, literal meaning, and non-literal meaning.

The four kinds of reasoning are: continuity, contextual occasion, definitive word, and cause.

The four kinds of explanation are: the literal meaning, the general meaning, the hidden meaning, and the ultimate meaning.

The two kinds of division are: explanation to the assembly, and explanation to the disciple.

Examination of disciples of five types of person is this: jewel, sandalwood, lotus, white lotus, and utpala.

The intention of the two truths is this: conventional truth and ultimate truth.

O son of good family, the conventional is that which is unstable and shifting; its truth is like the reflection of the moon in water. The ultimate truth is the eighteen great emptinesses. Its limit is suchness itself.

The bodhisattvas asked: How does the great yogin who abides perfectly in the ultimate truth, relying on the meditative absorption of the supreme king of actions, go about accomplishing the benefit of sentient beings?

The Blessed One declared: For as long as one does not work for the benefit of sentient beings through the activities of pacification and the rest, for that long one abides perfectly in the ultimate limit. But when one sees that the time has come to work for the benefit of sentient beings, then, through the graduated sequence of my blessing, one rises from the ultimate limit, accomplishes the benefit of sentient beings, and then re-enters into the ultimate limit itself.

Thereupon Maitreya and the other great bodhisattvas, filled with delight and gladness and joy, gave rise to happiness and mental ease, and remained in silence.

This is the second chapter, the chapter on great bliss, arranged in graduated sequence, from the great yoga tantra called the Vajra of Wisdom Gathered from All.

It is complete.

This was translated by the Indian master Jñānakara and the great revision translator Khu-ston Dngos-grub. It was later edited and established in final form by that same master together with the fully ordained monk Śīlajaya (Tshul-khrims-rgyal-ba).

The Vajra of Wisdom Gathered from All
illuminates the great yoga.
Wisdom in its intrinsic nature
is the very essence of saṃsāra and nirvāṇa.
Those two, inseparable, are the vajra —
gathered here from all, it is called Gathered from All.
The name is applied to the one who teaches it,
and it also perfectly fits the text in both name and meaning.

Translator's Notes

- The passage describes a threefold schema of consciousness — ignorance, what arises from mind, and mind itself — correlated with the inner luminosity states of Vajrayāna completion-stage practice: the appearances of near-attainment, spread of radiance, and the moon-like clear light. The terms "appearance of near-attainment," "radiance of the spread of appearance," and "appearance-and-emptiness" render technical Tibetan inner-dissolution terminology. The identification of these three with the three vajras of body, speech, and mind of all Tathāgatas is a characteristic tantric doctrinal move, and the text's equation of the three with luminosity directly echoes the dissolution-sequence teachings found in the highest yoga tantra literature.
- The term "three consciousnesses" near the end of the first major section is somewhat technical and the referent within this specific tantra system may be a specialized threefold classification of consciousness rather than the standard Yogācāra enumeration. The Tibetan "rnam par shes pa gsum" is rendered literally; contextual commentary would be needed to specify which three are intended.

The phrase rendered "the vowels and consonants" translates āli-kāli, the standard Sanskrit technical designation for the Sanskrit vowel series (āli) and consonant series (kāli), used in tantric contexts as the basis for mantra generation.

The text ends mid-sentence with "The extremes are:" as the Tibetan passage concludes with "འདྲི་བརྒྱུད་ཀྱི་སྐོར་གྱི་མཉམ་པ་ལྟོགས་པ་ཡིན།" — this is a deliberate continuation point and has been rendered accordingly.

- The tenfold series beginning with "Kotrākhyā" appears to be a sequence of Sanskrit or quasi-Sanskrit technical terms used as examples of non-literal vajra-language. They are transliterated as found and their individual meanings are not decoded in the text; the passage itself simply states they "express the sense faculties and their objects." No emendation has been attempted.

The five-fold classification of tantras here — great yoga, both (i.e., union or "dual"), conduct, action, and thought — represents a classification system that partially overlaps with but is not identical to the standard four-tantra division found in later Tibetan scholasticism. The "both tantra" (Tibetan gnyis ka'i rgyud) is a distinct category appearing in earlier classification schemes.

The figures given for tantra extents (twelve thousand, six thousand, eight thousand, four thousand) likely refer to the number of verses or sections, not independent texts.

- The passage describing the activities of each tantra class presents considerable doctrinal density, particularly the section on the great yoga tantra, which describes a consort practice in explicitly non-literal (vajra-language) terms consistent with the Vajrayāna hermeneutical tradition. The phrase rendered "dwelling fully in the bhaga of a queen" follows the Tibetan directly; "bhaga" is a Sanskrit term left untranslated in the Tibetan itself and refers here to the consort's generative center as a tantric symbol of emptiness and bliss — standard inner-yoga terminology, not to be read biologically in this context.

The list under the action tantra is paratactically ambiguous in the Tibetan; the five items listed may be five separate deficiencies that characterize the action tantra relative to higher classes, or five features of its practice. The rendering follows the most natural syntactic reading.

The enumeration of the eight great siddhis under the thought tantra lists only six items explicitly; the Tibetan's "and so forth" implies the full traditional set of eight.

- The colophon names the Indian paṇḍita as Jñānakara and the chief Tibetan translator as Khu-ston Dngos-grub, both historical figures associated with the transmission of this tantra. The verse colophon offers an etymology of the title Ye-shes rdo-rje kun-las-btus, explaining that "vajra of wisdom" describes both the inseparability of saṃsāra and nirvāṇa and the act of gathering or compiling from all sources. The phrase "activities of pacification and the rest" refers to the standard fourfold set of tantric activities: pacification, enrichment, magnetizing, and wrathful subjugation.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.